

destination, so it's up to us to set our own paths, and to define our own ideas of success and happiness, financial and otherwise. This is actually fairly well-documented by psychologists, who call it the 'hedonic treadmill', a theory that explains, in part, why a sense of fulfilment and wellbeing is so difficult for people to achieve, especially when it comes to money. It's something that can be applied to several elements of our financial wellbeing, from spending to saving and to goal planning. We'll talk about this in greater detail a little later on.

I find that it's important to remember that money has a life of its own outside of your experience of it, because some things, such as generational wealth, nepotism, stagnating wages and exploding house prices, are just not within your control. There is a little comfort in that, because remembering the external influences on our financial wellbeing means that we don't accidentally take more responsibility for it than is healthy. Berating yourself for messing up something that you don't even have any control over is *not* a healthy way to live life, and that applies to money just as it applies to any other area. The good news is that acknowledging the factors that are not within our control means that we can better focus on those that are.

Despite its importance, our financial health is not something we're really taught to look after. It should be as elementary as basic hygiene, and yet we are often left to figure it out for ourselves, leaving many of us feeling confused and alone. To the bafflement of many people, including me, financial literacy